

WHAT IS THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A GERUND AND A PRESENT PARTICIPLE

What is the difference between a gerund and a present participle? Both a gerund and a present participle come from a verb, and both end in – *ing*. However, each has a different function. A gerund acts like a noun while a present participle acts like a verb or adjective.

Example: **snowboarding**

Snowboarding is fun (gerund). He is **snowboarding** (present participle).

Snowboarding can be a gerund or a present participle.

When *snowboarding* is a gerund, it acts like a noun. It can be a subject, an object, the object of a preposition, or a subject complement.

- **Snowboarding** is a winter sport. [**snowboarding** = subject] □ I love **snowboarding**. [**snowboarding** = object]
- I am excited by **snowboarding**. [**snowboarding** = object of a preposition]
- One popular sport is **snowboarding**. [**snowboarding** = subject complement]

When *snowboarding* is a present participle, it is part of a continuous verb tense.

- Right now, the athlete **is snowboarding**. [**is snowboarding** = present continuous]
- He **was snowboarding** yesterday afternoon. [**was snowboarding** = past continuous]

Unlike a gerund, a present participle can act like an adjective that modifies a noun or follows the 'be' verb.

Example: **exciting**

An exciting time was had by all!

The word *exciting* is a present participle used as an adjective to modify a noun or to follow the verb to be.

- The **exciting** ride made the people scream. [adjective + noun]
- People enjoyed the **exciting** roller coaster. [adjective + noun] □ The roller coaster is **exciting**. [be verb + adjective]

Now YOU try: Look at the sentences below. Decide whether the underlined – ‘ing’ word is acting like a noun, part of a verb, or an adjective.

1. What an amazing movie! I want to watch it again!
2. Speaking English well takes a long time.
3. He cares about getting a good job.
4. Shh! I am trying to sleep.
5. My friends and I were sitting in a café and talking.
6. The directions were very confusing.
7. They have been studying for a long time and want to take a break.
8. She loves travelling.

Exercise: Gerund or Participle?

Identify whether the -ing word/phrase is a **gerund** (used as a noun) or a **participle** (used as an adjective/description).

1. Swimming every morning keeps me healthy. gerund
2. The girl running across the street is my cousin. present participle
3. He is interested in learning new languages. gerund
4. Falling leaves covered the ground. present participle
5. I don't mind waiting for a few minutes. gerund
6. The students preparing for the test looked very nervous.
7. Cooking is one of her greatest passions. gerund
8. The man sitting next to me is a famous actor. present participle